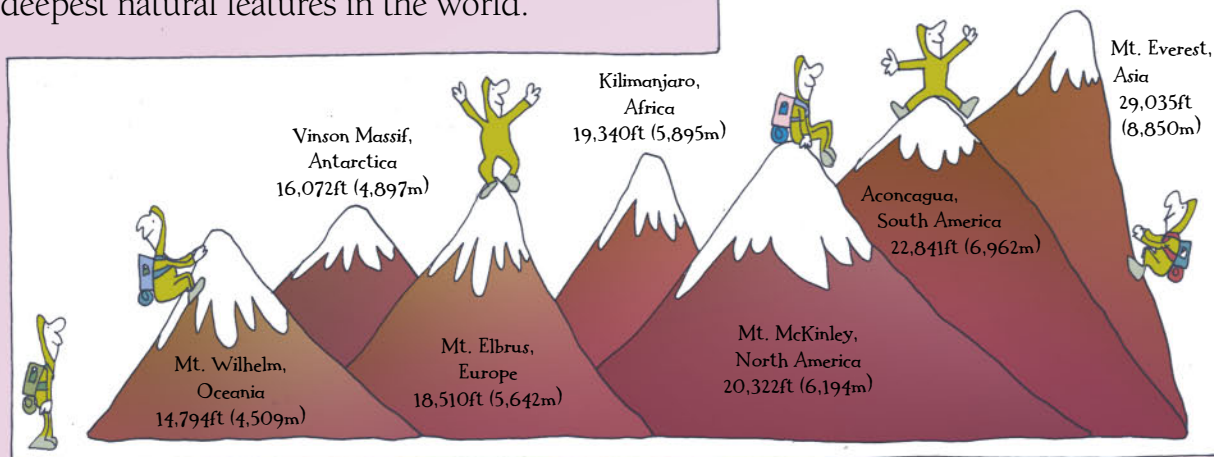


COMPARATIVELY SPEAKING

Everyone likes compiling lists—their top 10 favorite books or CDs, or their top five places to visit. Geographers do it, too, compiling lists of the highest and longest, biggest and deepest natural features in the world.

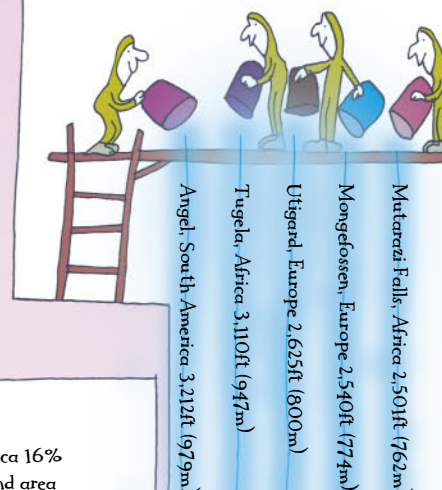
Mountains

All 14 of the mighty mountains that are more than 26,256ft (8,000m) high are in the Himalayas, and all 109 mountains more than 23,630ft (7,200m) are in the mountain ranges of central Asia. Therefore, below is a comparison of the highest mountain of each continent.



Waterfalls

The height of a waterfall is measured by its vertical drop from top to bottom, although this fall can be broken by rocky outcrops on its way down. This causes disputes when comparing the heights, but every geographer agrees that Angel Falls in Venezuela is the world's highest waterfall.

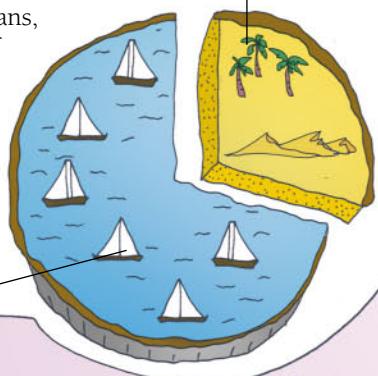


Land versus water

The land that we live on accounts for less than one-third of the world's surface; more than two-thirds are the watery habitats of oceans, seas, and lakes. And if sea levels continue to rise with global warming, this ratio will continue to increase.

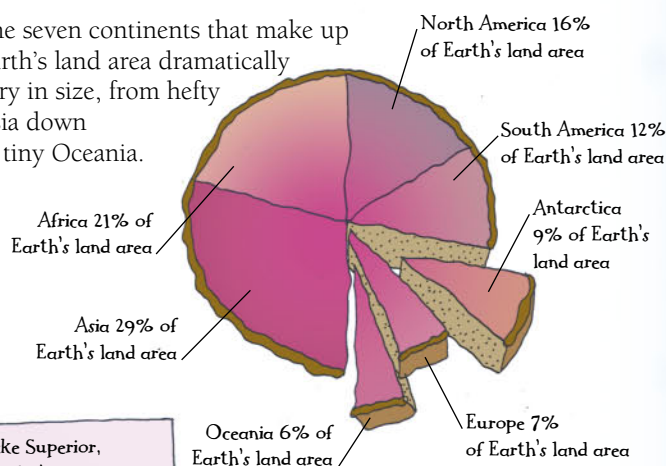
Oceans and seas
70.8% of Earth's surface

Land 29.2% of Earth's surface



Continents

The seven continents that make up Earth's land area dramatically vary in size, from hefty Asia down to tiny Oceania.



Lakes

It is rather confusing that the world's largest lake is called a sea, but the Caspian Sea is, by any definition, a lake, since it is completely surrounded by land.



Rivers

There is much debate about which river is really the longest—the Nile or the Amazon—due to irritating uncertainties about which tributary is the river's main source, and which direction the river takes through its delta to the sea. The Nile usually wins, but only barely!

